

By **Shashi Tharoor**

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The Toxin of Hate

Injected into our body politic for narrow electoral gain, the communal poison has envenomed society and turned India into something that it never was

When the Editor asks, 'Is the Divide Deepening?', I do not find myself thinking immediately of the depressingly familiar tragedies that must have prompted his question—the communal rioting, mob lynchings and cow vigilantism that have scarred our society—nor even the manufactured controversies over hijab, halal meat and azaan on loudspeakers that have recently served to marginalise our country's Muslim minority. Instead, I find myself thinking of three seemingly trivial anecdotes that came to my attention in recent weeks, which illustrated the divide more directly, if less starkly, for me.

Episode One: In Jaipur recently, I met a blonde Lebanese lady who had been coming to India for 15 years to deal in handicrafts and jewellery. Visibly foreign, she had been warmly welcomed in the past; when she introduced herself as Nour, people would say, "Oh, what a lovely name! We have the same name in India! We know it means 'light'!" Today, she says, things have changed. When she says her name is Nour, the reaction she gets is immediate: "Oh, you are Muslim?" The question, and the tone of the query, says it all. She is less sure now that she will be coming back as often.

Episode Two: A former Indian ambassador, who had enjoyed something of a reputation during his MEA career as a hawk on Pakistan and on Islamist terrorism, told me of a friend of his, an eminent surgeon in Kabul. The surgeon, alarmed by the rising influence of the Taliban in his country, decided, at this ambassador's prompting, to send his wife and children to India (not Pakistan!) to live and study, free from resurgent Islamic fundamentalism. They rented a flat in Gurgaon, enrolled in a good school. But within a year they realised this was no longer the India the surgeon had remembered when he took his decision. The most painful blow came when the children's playmates in their apartment building announced to them, "Our parents told us not to play with you because you are Muslim." My ambassador friend, in shock and despair, said he advised the surgeon, "Take your children to Dubai or London. I am ashamed that I encouraged you to bring them up in my country."

Episode Three: An Indian at the United Nations, an experienced peace negotiator who had served in many trouble spots across the Middle East, found himself in an Arab country in a tense meeting with an Islamic militant, complete with beard, turban and Kalashnikov. The ice broke: even though it was Ramadan, the militant lit up, offered the UN man a cigarette, laughed and joked expansively as they discussed a thorny issue. Then he asked, almost casually: "And where are you from?" When the UN official said "India", the mood changed instantly. "India? I have heard how you are treating Muslims there. Get out, UN man, or I will not be responsible for what happens to you." The UN official tried to remonstrate that the militant was misinformed, as did the European UN official accompanying him, but the militant would not be mollified. His sources, he said, were multiple: he might be a militant, but he read and watched the world media. The meeting was over. The Indian got out by the skin of his teeth.

Yes, I am aware of the limitations